Arctos CAN Interface

How the arm's motors and CAN bus actually work

Consolidated from project debugging logs, source inspection and bench testing

September 2026

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1 About these documents

This is the reference document: how the bus works, how the protocol is framed, how to turn encoder counts into joint angles, and what has actually been verified against hardware rather than assumed. It is deliberately not a step-by-step procedure.

There are four documents in this set and they do not overlap:

- **Arctos_CAN_Interface** — this one. Background and reference.
- **Nema_17_MKS42D_SOP** — bringing up a NEMA 17 joint on an MKS SERVO42D. Joints A, B and C.
- **Nema_23_MKS57D_SOP** — bringing up a NEMA 23 joint on an MKS SERVO57D. Joint X. Largely unverified; see that document's opening.
- **BASIC_CAN_COMMANDS** — terminal commands only. Setting the interface up, talking to a motor, shutting down to unplug.

This set replaces `arctos_motor_guide`, `sop_nema17`, `sop_nema23`, `arctos_CAN_ROS2_SOP_updated` and `arctos_motor_can_cheat_sheet_updated`. Section 15 lists the things that were *wrong* in those files, so nothing is silently re-derived from a stale copy.

2 Core concepts

2.1 CAN bus, in one paragraph

CAN is a differential two-wire multi-drop bus. Every device shares the same pair, CAN_H and CAN_L, plus a common ground, and each device is addressed by an ID. Every node must agree on the bitrate; this arm runs at **500 kbit/s**. Because all nodes share one pair, two devices configured with the same CAN ID will collide and neither will behave correctly.

2.2 Gearboxes and closed-loop steppers, in one paragraph

Each joint is a stepper motor driving a reduction gearbox. The reduction multiplies torque and divides both speed and angular error: through a 67.82:1 gearbox, one motor revolution is only about 5.31° at the joint. The MKS controllers are closed-loop — a magnetic encoder on the motor shaft reports true position, so the controller can tell that it has fallen behind. Two consequences matter constantly in practice. The encoder measures the **motor shaft, not the joint output**. And a stalled stepper converts its full phase current into heat, with no motion to carry it away.

3 Hardware

3.1 Joint, motor and CAN ID map

Joint	Role	CAN ID	Motor / driver	Gear ratio
X	Base and waist rotation	`0x01`	NEMA 23 / SERVO57D	13.5:1
Y	not confirmed	`0x02`	—	150.0:1
Z	not confirmed	`0x03`	—	150.0:1
A	Elbow	`0x04`	NEMA 17 / SERVO42D	48.0:1
B	Wrist rotation	`0x05`	NEMA 17 / SERVO42D	67.82:1
C	Wrist joint	`0x06`	NEMA 17 / SERVO42D	67.82:1

Caution: A driver can be found on the wrong CAN ID — fix the panel, not the map

The table above is the *intended* assignment and matches `arctos_controller.yaml`. A controller's panel can hold a different value. On 2026-09-02 a scan with only Joint B connected returned a single responder at `0x06`, which is Joint C's ID: that driver's panel had simply been saved wrong. The work done that day was on Joint B regardless of the ID it answered on.

When a scan disagrees with this table, that is evidence the **panel needs reprogramming**, not evidence the map is wrong. Reprogram the driver rather than editing the map, and never drive a joint until the scan and the map agree. Joint A's `0x04` and its 48:1 ratio are empirically verified; the rest are config values.

3.2 Confirmed per-joint parameters

Everything below was established on the machine, not read from a config file. Blank means not yet confirmed — treat it as unknown rather than assuming a default.

J	Board	Gear	Remap	CW byte	Endstops	Envelope
X	57D	13.5	no	`0x00`	one, `IN_2` (CW side)	—
Y	57D	150.0	no	`0x80`	`IN_1` CW, `IN_2` CCW	158.24°
Z	42D	150.0	**yes**	`0x00`	`IN_1`=`En` CW, `IN_2`=`Dir` CCW	124.4° ±0.3
A	42D	48.0	**yes**	`0x00`	`IN_1`=`En`, `IN_2`=`Dir`	—
B	42D	67.82	**yes**	`0x00`	`IN_1`=`En`, `IN_2`=`Dir`	—
C	42D	67.82	**yes**	`0x80`	`IN_1`=`En`, `IN_2`=`Dir`	—

Caution: The clockwise byte does not transfer between joints

`0x00` is clockwise on X and Z and counter-clockwise on Y and C. Four joints, no pattern. An earlier draft proposed that "encoder counting down means clockwise" held across joints; Y disproved it. Each mapping in the table was established by watching the joint turn. **All six are now confirmed**, B being the last, on 2026-10-30. `joint_move.py` refuses to move a joint whose mapping is blank rather than guess, because a guess is a coin flip on direction; `-assume-cw` exists to make that first observed move deliberately.

Caution: Per-joint quirks that have each cost a session

- **X has only one endstop**, on `IN_2`. `GoHome` homes to `IN_1`, so it would never terminate — **never send `0x91` to X**.
- **Y's gears slip above speed 25**, losing ∼7° per traverse at 50 and ∼20° at 150. Calibrate it at 25.
- **Z and C are remapped**; their endstops are on `En` and `Dir`, not `IN_1`, and `Com` must be tied high.
- **X's detection zone is 10–17° wide** but releases in 0.062° going the other way, so home must sit clear of it. Y's and Z's are only a few degrees.
- **B is stick-slip.** It jams for roughly 2.9 s, builds torque and breaks free, completing the move. Drive it with `-stall-window 5`; the default 1.5 s patience aborts it mid-stick and reports a stall that is not one. It also stalls at 1200 mA and completes at 1600 mA.
- **C is half a differential wrist** with B. Driving it alone produces a blend of both wrist axes, not a clean rotation about one.

Caution: Always confirm a CAN ID against real hardware

Run the read-only scan before trusting any table, including the one above. It sends only the `0x31` query and never enables coils:

```
cd ~/arctos_ws/src/arctos_can_control/arctos_can_control
python3 can_id_scan.py --channel can0 --ids 1-16
```

3.3 Motor specifications

Parameter	NEMA 17 / SERVO42D	NEMA 23 / SERVO57D
Holding torque	24 N · cm	1.8 N · m
Rated current	1.2 A	2.8 A
Shaft diameter	5 mm	6.35 mm
Step angle	1.8°, 200 full steps per rev	1.8°, 200 full steps per rev
Microstepping	16 times, 3200 pulses per rev	16 times, 3200 pulses per rev
Encoder	16384 counts per rev, 14-bit	16384 counts per rev, 14-bit
Joints	A, B, C	X

Caution: Do not confuse motor steps, microstep pulses and encoder counts

Three different resolutions are in play, and mixing them is the single most common arithmetic error in this project.

- **200** full steps per motor revolution, the physical stepping resolution.
- **3200** microstep pulses per motor revolution, the scale that `0xFD` position commands are expressed in.

- **16384** encoder counts per motor revolution, the scale that `0x31` reports in.

One microstep pulse is 16384/3200 = 5.12 encoder counts. Commanded motion and measured motion are therefore never in the same units.

3.4 CANable 2 adapter and wiring

- USB VID:PID `16d0:117e`.
- It contains its own CAN controller. Do **not** add an external MCP2515 module in series with it.
- Only three wires are needed between adapter and controller: CAN_H, CAN_L and GND. Do *not* connect the CANable's power lines to the motor controller.

```
Ubuntu host -> USB -> CANable 2 -> CAN_H / CAN_L / GND
            -> MKS controller (SERVO42D or SERVO57D) -> joint motor
```

3.5 Bus termination check, power off

With everything powered off, measure resistance between CAN_H and CAN_L.

Reading	Meaning
About 60 Ω	Correct. Two 120 Ω terminators in parallel
About 120 Ω	Only one terminator present
Open circuit	Wiring is disconnected
Very low	Possible short

4 The CAN interface on Ubuntu

The CANable presents as a serial device, and `slcand` bridges it to a Linux network interface. This has to be rebuilt every time the adapter is plugged in or re-enumerates. The commands themselves are in `BASIC_CAN_COMMANDS`; what follows is why they are what they are.

Caution: The `slcand` bitrate flag is a coded index, not a number

`-s0` is 10k, `-s1` 20k, `-s2` 50k, `-s3` 100k, `-s4` 125k, `-s5` 250k, **`-s6` 500k**, `-s7` 800k, `-s8` 1M. This arm is 500 kbit/s, so `-s6` is correct. Earlier scripts in this project used `-s3` and silently attached at 100 kbit/s, which presents as a completely dead bus.

Caution: On slcan the bitrate is set at attach time and `ip` cannot show it

Do not use `ip link set can0 up type can bitrate 500000`. That netlink attribute is for native CAN controller drivers and is not supported on slcan. As a result `ip -details link show can0` reports `bitrate 0` and `clock 0` on a perfectly healthy CANable. This is normal and is not a fault to chase. An older version of this documentation told the reader to verify by looking for `bitrate 500000`; that check can never pass on this hardware.

Caution: Kernel CAN error counters are meaningless on slcan

The re-started, bus-errors, arbit-lost, error-warn, error-pass and bus-off counters in `ip -details -statistics link show can0` are not populated by the slcan driver. They read zero regardless of what the bus is doing. Do not use them as evidence that a bus is healthy, and note that the "total silence with zero bus errors implies no CAN transceiver" heuristic in Section 12.1 needs a native CAN controller to mean anything.

5 Controller panel configuration

Confirm these on the controller's own display before attempting CAN communication.

Setting	Value
CAN ID	the joint's ID from the map above
CAN Rate	`500`
CAN Response, shown as CANRSP	`ENABLE`
CAN CRC	`SUM-8`
Working current	at or below the motor's rated current
Working mode	see the caution below

Save and power-cycle the controller after any change. The CAN ID in particular must be committed, not merely displayed.

Caution: Set the working current to the motor's rating, not the panel default

A controller in this project was found storing a 3000 mA default against a motor rated 1.2 A, roughly two and a half times over. Check this on every new controller.

Caution: A working-mode mismatch can imitate a communication fault

The ROS 2 driver defines six modes and defaults to `CR_vFOC`, which is 2:

```
CR_OPEN = 0, CR_CLOSE = 1, CR_vFOC = 2,
SR_OPEN = 3, SR_CLOSE = 4, SR_vFOC = 5
```

If the panel's mode disagrees with what a motion command assumes, the controller can accept a frame and acknowledge its checksum without rotating the shaft. Confirm the mode before concluding that a "no motion" result is a wiring or CAN problem.

6 The MKS CAN protocol

6.1 Frame structure and checksum

Every frame is `[command byte][data bytes][checksum byte]`, where the checksum is an 8-bit sum that **includes the CAN ID**:

```
def checksum(motor_id, data_bytes):
    return (motor_id + sum(data_bytes)) & 0xFF
```

Frame, no checksum	CAN ID	Arithmetic	Checksum
31	0x04	0x31+0x04	35
31	0x06	0x31+0x06	37
3A	0x05	0x3A+0x05	3F
F3 01	0x05	0xF3+0x01+0x05	F9
F7	0x06	0xF7+0x06	FD

The checksum differs per joint, so a frame copied from another joint's documentation is silently rejected. `BASIC_CAN_COMMANDS` has a ready-made table for every ID on this arm.

Caution: Never hand-invent a checksum, and never reuse another joint's frame

Omitted or incorrect checksum bytes were the direct cause of several "the motor ignored my command" failures in this project. Compute it from the formula every time, including for the emergency stop.

6.2 Command reference

Name	Byte	Status
`QUERY_MOTOR`	`0xF1`	Liveness check. Answers `F1 01`.
`READ_ENCODER`	`0x31`	**Verified. Use this one.**
`READ_ENCODER` carry form	`0x30`	Superseded. See Section 15.
`READ_VELOCITY`	`0x32`	Responds; zero at rest. Layout unconfirmed.
`READ_ERROR`	`0x39`	Signed 32-bit deficit. Grows when stalled.
`READ_ENABLE_STATE`	`0x3A`	`01` enabled, `00` disabled. Verified.
`READ_SHAFT_PROTECTION`	`0x3E`	`00` clear. Non-zero latches the driver.
`READ_IO`	`0x34`	Input and output pin states. Verified. Section 10.
`SET_WORKING_MODE`	`0x82`	See the panel caution.
`SET_EN_ACTIVE`	`0x85`	`00` low, `01` high, `02` always on.
`SET_AXIS_ZERO`	`0x92`	Zeroes the counter where it stands. No motion.
`SET_HOME_PARAMS`	`0x90`	Trigger level, direction, speed, `EndLimit`.
`GO_HOME`	`0x91`	Runs onto the limit. **Unlocks the shaft** if `EndLimit=1`.
`LIMIT_PORT_REMAP`	`0x9E`	**Required for 42D endstops here.** No read-back.
`ENABLE_SHAFT_PROTECTION`	`0x88`	**Avoid.** False positives, and it latches.
`ENABLE_MOTOR`	`0xF3`	`01` enable, `00` disable. Verified.

Name	Byte	Status
RELATIVE_POSITION	0xF4	Unsafe packing. See the motion section.
ABSOLUTE_POSITION	0xF5	**Unsafe.** See the motion section.
SPEED_CONTROL	0xF6	Not exercised.
EMERGENCY_STOP	0xF7	Verified, with checksum.
POSITION_CONTROL	0xFD	**Verified. Preferred for all motion.**

6.3 Reading the encoder

Use 0x31. The response is [0x31][6 bytes signed position][checksum], where the six bytes are a big-endian signed 48-bit multi-turn count on the 16384-counts-per-revolution scale:

```
raw48 = int.from_bytes(data[1:7], byteorder="big", signed=True)
motor_degrees = raw48 * 360.0 / 16384
joint_degrees = motor_degrees / gear_ratio
```

This is multi-turn and does not wrap at one revolution. It resets to approximately zero when the controller is power-cycled, so it is a relative reference from power-on, not an absolute machine coordinate.

Caution: The encoder measures the motor shaft, not the joint output

Gearbox backlash and any lost motion downstream of the motor are invisible to this encoder. It cannot measure output-side backlash; that needs a dial indicator on the output.

6.4 Encoder non-linearity

The magnetic encoder carries a once-per-revolution sinusoidal error caused by the sensing magnet sitting slightly off-centre on the shaft. Measured on Joint A over 6725 samples: **1.465° peak to peak at the motor shaft**, about 0.407% of a revolution.

Two practical consequences:

- It cancels over any whole number of motor revolutions. Choosing a step size that is an integer number of motor turns makes it vanish — Joint A steps of exactly 6 motor revolutions landed at 100.0% every time, where 90° motor-shaft steps scattered between 98.7 and 101.4%.
- Through a reduction it becomes negligible at the joint: 1.465° through 48:1 is 0.031°.

Repeatability is unaffected. Returning to the same shaft angle repeats to better than one encoder count. Absolute readings carry the cyclic error; relative and repeat positioning do not.

7 Motion commands

Use POSITION_CONTROL, 0xFD. It is what the project's own working jog code uses and the only motion command verified safe here.

```
[0xFD]
[direction | ((speed >> 8) & 0x0F)]   direction 0x00 fwd, 0x80 reverse
[speed & 0xFF]                        speed is approximately motor rpm
[accel]
[(pulses >> 16) & 0xFF]               ALWAYS-POSITIVE magnitude, on the
[(pulses >>  8) & 0xFF]               3200-pulses-per-motor-rev scale
[pulses & 0xFF]
[checksum]
```

$$\text{pulses} = |\text{joint degrees}| \times \frac{3200 \times \text{gear ratio}}{360}$$

The driver replies with an unsolicited two-frame status sequence: `FD 01` for "started", then `FD 02` for "complete" if the commanded distance was actually achieved. **The absence of `FD 02` is the reliable signal that a command did not finish.**

Caution: Do not use `0xF5`, and be careful with `0xF4`

`0xF5` packs an absolute target through a plain `& 0xFFFFFF`. On a joint whose raw counter had drifted to roughly −274000 counts, a small intended nudge became an enormous, non-settling, uninterruptible move that required cutting motor power. `0xF4` packs a possibly-negative delta the same way. The `0xFD` pattern above, a separate direction byte plus an always-positive magnitude, does not have this failure mode.

Caution: Never retry a stalled command into an obstruction

Re-sending the same command to a joint that has not moved changes nothing except the motor's temperature. Nine consecutive full-torque retries into a hard stop drove one joint's internal position error to −124374 counts and cost a cooldown to recover from. If a step under-delivers, stop, or back off and re-attempt once.

Caution: A repeatable stop angle is mechanical, not roughness

Rough gear mesh varies. If a joint stops at the *same* angle to the encoder count on attempt after attempt, and the back-off also delivers nothing, that is a hard mechanical limit. On Joint B this pattern turned out to be a gear seated in the wrong position; once corrected the joint swept the same range with zero unstick cycles. Open the gearbox rather than working at it.

---

8 Speed and its limits

The `speed` field is very close to motor rpm. Measured on a bare NEMA 17 with no load:

Commanded	Actual	Behaviour
10–225	tracks to within 0.5%	linear
250	98.7%	edge of linear
275–325	96.5% down to 90%	rolling off
350 plus	saturates near 310 rpm	losing steps

8.1 Measured ceilings, per joint

That table is a bare motor on a bench. A joint drags its gearbox with it and the ceiling falls accordingly, so treat the no-load numbers as an upper bound and measure each joint.

Joint	Driver	Gear	Linear to	Saturates
bench, no load	SERVO42D	none	225 rpm	about 310 rpm
B	SERVO42D	67.82:1	150 rpm	about 165 rpm

Joint B was measured on 2026-09-02 over a 48° arc. Commanded 150 tracked at 99.7%; commanded 165, 175, 200, 225 and 300 all produced 159 to 165 rpm. Past saturation, extra commanded speed buys nothing but current and heat. The measurement was repeated at eight times the acceleration to confirm the ramp was not the limiter, which moved the result by only about 4%.

Caution: Over-commanding speed did not lose position on a geared joint

`0xFD` commands a pulse *count*, not a duration. On Joint B every trial from 150 through 300 commanded delivered its 48° arc to +0.01%: past saturation the move simply takes longer, it does not drop pulses. Silent position loss requires actual slip. Do not carry the no-load "loses steps above 250" result across to a geared joint automatically — verify which behaviour the joint in front of you shows.

Caution: Heat is the real limit on any speed or reliability testing

A ladder of trials run back to back overheats the motor even when no single trial is aggressive. Eleven trials with one-second gaps was enough to have to stop and let a joint cool; fifteen seconds between trials was not. There is no temperature-read opcode on these drivers, so software cannot detect this. Budget total energized time, not just peak current, and stop as soon as you have the answer.

9 Converting encoder counts to joint degrees

$$\text{counts per joint degree} = \frac{\text{gear ratio} \times 16384}{360}$$

Gear ratio	Counts per joint degree	Joints
13.5:1	614.4	X
48.0:1	2184.5	A
67.82:1	3086.56	B, C
150.0:1	6826.7	Y, Z

Caution: Three wrong conversion constants exist in this project's history

Do not use any of them.

1. "About 3300 counts per 90°" describes the *motor shaft*, not the joint. Through 67.82:1 that same motion is only about 1.07° of joint travel.
2. `COUNTS_PER_REV = 16050`. The encoder is 14-bit, so 16384 is correct and source-verified.
3. `pulses_per_degree = -813.0` in `mks_driver.py`, off by roughly 3.8 times, with an accompanying "safety cage" that estimated limits using a different multiplier than the one actually transmitted, so it could not reliably block an unsafe command.

Use only the formula above.

10 Endstops and homing

10.1 Where the sensor actually connects

There are two wiring schemes and they are mutually exclusive. The vendor default puts a limit switch on `EVCC`, `EGND` and `IN_1`, all on the same green terminal block as the CAN pair — top to bottom, that block is `5V`, `GND`, `IN`, `CAN_H`, `CAN_L`. The silkscreen is split, `5V/GND/IN` printed above the block and `CAN H L` below it, which is easy to misread if you only look at one end.

This build does not use that scheme. It follows the Arctos documentation, which for the 42D axes enables *limit port remap* and moves the limits to the opposite connector: left limit to `En`, right limit to `Dir`, with `Com` tied to the matching high level. `En` and `Dir` are opto-isolated, so with `Com` floating they register nothing at all.

Caution: The 42D has no `IN_2`, which is why the remap exists

Per the vendor manual's IO table, `IN_1` (home / left limit) is present on both 57D and 42D, but `IN_2` (right limit) is 57D only. Remapping is how a 42D gets a second endstop. On a 57D the remap is optional, since that board has a real `IN_2`.

Caution: No DIP switch is involved on the 42D

The `SW1` pin-2 instruction that circulates for these boards belongs to the 57D. On the 42D, `EVCC`/`EGND` is the board's own 5 V, rated 20 mA — the whole budget for the sensor and its indicator LEDs.

10.2 Enabling the remap

```
# LIMIT_PORT_REMAP (0x9E), enable = 01, CAN ID 0x06
# checksum 0x06 + 0x9E + 0x01 = 0xA5
cansend can0 006#9E01A5
# reply 9E 01 A5 -> status 1, set success
```

The manual documents `0x9E` as a write only. **Nothing reports whether remap is currently on**, so it cannot be queried — only set. Two further conditions must hold or it does nothing useful: the driver must be in a serial (`SR_`) work mode, because in any `CR_` mode `En` and `Dir` are the pulse interface's own enable and direction inputs; and `Com` must be wired.

10.3 Reading the pins: `0x34`

The reply is `[0x34][status][checksum]`. The status byte:

Bit	Pin	After remap, reports
bit 0	`IN_1`	the `En` pin
bit 1	`IN_2`	the `Dir` pin
bit 2	`OUT_1`	stall indication, 57D only
bit 3	`OUT_2`	reserved, 57D only
bits 4–7	reserved	

Reading `0x34` does *not* require `EndLimit`; that setting only governs whether the driver acts on a limit. Measured on Joint C with a dual-output hall sensor, one output per magnet pole:

Byte	Meaning	
`0x03`	both idle	resting state
`0x02`	bit 0 low	north pole on `En`
`0x01`	bit 1 low	south pole on `Dir`

Both are **active low**, so the default `Hm_Trig = Low` is correct and needs no change.

Caution: A resting `0x01` before remap looks identical to a dead sensor

Without the remap, bit 0 reports the physical `IN_1` terminal. On this build that terminal is deliberately empty, so it idles high forever regardless of the magnet. Two sessions and two different sensors were spent on this before the cause was found. If an endstop reads nothing, re-send `9E 01` before suspecting the wiring.

10.4 Homing a joint in practice

The procedure that has worked on X, Y and Z, and which does not depend on any driver setting that cannot be read back:

1. **Search** toward the chosen limit at a fixed slow speed, watching `0x34` directly and stopping on the bit yourself. Do not use `GoHome (0x91)`: its direction lives in `Hm_Dir`, which cannot

be queried, and the manual says the motor "will keep running until it hits the limit switch" — with no switch on the watched input there is no terminating condition.

2. **Record the trigger** position. That edge is the reference.
3. **Step clear of the detection zone.** Parking inside it leaves the joint sitting on an asserted limit at its own home.
4. `SET_AXIS_ZERO (0x92)` where it rests. Readings then become joint angles instead of offsets from an arbitrary power-on point.

Caution: A homed zero does not survive a power cycle

The encoder counter resets to zero at power-up regardless of what `0x92` was told earlier, so a joint reading `0` is not necessarily at home — it may simply have just been powered on. Re-home after any power interruption. This is the same reason a stored trigger position is only ever useful for choosing a search bound: Joint X's endstop was 112° from the start position one session, 173.8° the next and 290.1° the one after.

10.5 Making a homing reference repeatable

An endstop's trigger point is only a usable reference if it is approached the same way every time. Two effects, both measured:

Detection zones are asymmetric, and the sharp edge is directional. A magnet holds an input asserted over a band, not at a point. On Joint X that band runs 10–17° wide, and backing out of it releases the input after only **0.062°**. So the edge encountered on the way *in* is sharp and repeatable, while the far side is a plateau. Approaching from the other direction trips somewhere in the band and gives a different answer each time. Fix the approach direction and make it part of the procedure. Zone widths are per-joint: Joint Y's releases in 2–4° where X's takes 10–17.

Trigger position drifts with approach speed. The same endstop on Joint Y, approached clockwise twice, reported `raw` 411950 at speed 50 and 411633 at speed 25 — the faster approach recording the trigger further along in the direction of travel. That is detection-and-stop latency. The bias is small and systematic, so a joint homed at varying speeds has a reference that moves by roughly that much. Standardise on one slow speed for the final approach.

Repeatability with both controlled: **0.046°** across a 165° round trip.

Two-phase approach. Creeping the whole way is slow — Joint Y's full envelope takes about 165 s at speed 25. Running all but the last 15° at speed 150 and creeping the remainder covers it in about 40 s, with the same precision where it matters. Park the joint clear of the detection zone afterwards, or it sits on an asserted limit at its own home.

Caution: Absolute positions do not survive a power cycle

The encoder counter zeroes at power-on, and the arm may be moved between sessions. A previously recorded trigger position is a rough expectation, never a target — Joint X's endstop was 112° from the start position one session and 173.8° the next. Re-establish the reference by searching, then `SET_AXIS_ZERO (0x92)` so subsequent readings are joint angles.

10.6 When a sensor's LEDs say something impossible

On a dual-output sensor — one output per magnet pole, an LED on each — the two LEDs are mutually exclusive by physics. A single die cannot be presented with a north and a south pole at the same point, so **both LEDs lit at once is not a detection state**. Neither is both lit and unresponsive to a magnet: that is both outputs stuck, which is a supply or wiring fault rather than anything magnetic.

On these modules the indicator usually sits between `+V` and the output pin, so it lights when the output is pulled low. Both outputs held low — because the chip is not running, or its outputs are damaged, or the pins are shorted to ground — lights both LEDs permanently. Things that produce it:

- **Supply reversed or on the wrong pin.** A four-pin dual-output module (`+V`, `GND`, and two outputs) reversed end-for-end puts `+V` on an output and an output on `+V`. The chip is then fed through a pin that was never meant to carry it, and does not run.
- **Overvoltage.** These are 5 V parts. On a 42D, `EVCC`/`EGND` is the board's own 5 V rated 20 mA — two lit LEDs plus the die can approach that budget, and anything fed from a 12–24 V rail instead will be damaged outright.
- **Output pins shorted to ground** by a mis-landed wire, which pulls both indicators on regardless of what the sensor is doing.

Caution: A reversal damages the part; correcting the wiring does not undo it

These hall modules have **no reverse-polarity protection**. Feeding the supply backwards forward-biases the die's substrate diode, and the usual result is a destroyed output stage that latches — which lights both indicators permanently and never responds to a magnet again. So "it was plugged in backwards at first" is a sufficient explanation on its own, and the symptom will persist after the wiring is corrected.

What limits the damage is how hard the supply could push. On a 42D, `EVCC` is the board's own 5 V rated 20 mA, and that current limit may be enough to have saved a briefly reversed module — it is worth testing before assuming the part is dead.

Separate the sensor from the harness by swapping: put a *known-good* sensor from a working joint onto this joint's harness. If the good sensor works here, the original is dead and should be replaced. If the good sensor misbehaves here too, the fault is in the harness or the driver's `EVCC` rail — check that rail directly, since reverse current can damage it as well, and a driver that is perfectly healthy over CAN can still have a dead 5 V output.

Check the supply before suspecting the sensor: measure `+V` to `GND` at the module and confirm it reads about 5 V with the right polarity. A sensor whose LEDs respond correctly to each pole *separately* is working; that is the state to get back to before looking at anything on the CAN side.

10.7 Homing

`SET_HOME_PARAMS (0x90)` carries `homeTrig` (0 low, 1 high), `homeDir` (0 CW, 1 CCW), a 16-bit `homeSpeed` in rpm, and `EndLimit` (0 disable, 1 enable). `GO_HOME (0x91)` answers `0` fail, `1` started, `2` complete. The manual requires a `GoHome` after enabling `EndLimit` or changing any limit parameter.

Caution: `EndLimit=1` unlocks the shaft at the left limit

The manual is explicit: when `EndLimit` is enabled and a `GoHome` reaches the left limit switch, the driver **unlocks the shaft**. On a belted, gravity-loaded joint that is a drop. Test with the belt off. Set `EndLimit=0` if the axis must stay locked after homing.

11 Safety

Action	Frame	Example, Joint A at `0x04`
Enable coils	`F3 01 crc`	`cansend can0 004#F301F8`
Disable coils	`F3 00 crc`	`cansend can0 004#F300F7`
Emergency stop	`F7 crc`	`cansend can0 004#F7FB`

Recompute for the joint you are actually driving, or take the row from `BASIC_CAN_COMMANDS`.

Caution: Compute your joint's e-stop frame before you need it

A previous version of this documentation gave a joint's emergency stop as `cansend can0 001#F7F8`, addressed to CAN ID `0x01`, when the motor was not on that ID. It would have done nothing. Derive the frame for the joint in front of you, and keep it pasted in a second terminal before commanding motion.

Caution: Dropping coils on a gravity-loaded joint lets it fall

Several scripts in this package disable the motor in a `finally` block. On an unloaded bench motor that is harmless; on an assembled arm it removes holding torque. Know which you have before running one.

12 Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause and fix
`can0` does not exist	`slcand` died, usually because the adapter re-enumerated. Re-run the bring-up. Check `/dev/serial/by-id/` for the current device name.
Adapter present, `can0` missing after a replug	Expected. `slcand` does not restart itself. A udev rule keyed on the adapter's serial can automate this.
`ip` shows `bitrate 0`	Normal on slcan. Not a fault.
No response from any ID	Check panel CAN ID, CAN rate and CANRSP; check CAN_H, CAN_L and termination; confirm the driver is powered. If still silent see Section 12.1.

Symptom	Likely cause and fix
Command acknowledged, motor does not move	Distinguish "not being driven" from "driven but cannot move the load" — the bus cannot tell these apart. Disable coils and turn the joint by hand.
Motion for a few degrees, then nothing in either direction	If it cannot even back off, suspect a bind stiff enough to absorb full torque, a marginal motor phase connection, or a misassembled gear. Reseating a connector once took a joint's travel budget from 1.05° to 3.85°.
Stops at the same angle every attempt	Mechanical, not roughness. Open the gearbox. A gear in the wrong position produced exactly this on Joint B.
Gritty resistance by hand, stalls under power	Gear mesh needs lubrication. Use a plastic-safe PTFE or silicone grease. Petroleum jelly works as a diagnostic but migrates once warm.
Motor warm but not hot	Normal. Thermal shutdown makes a motor too hot to touch; warm is a stepper doing its job.
Driver stops responding mid-test	Check power and connectors first. This has been an accidental unplug more than once.
All drivers go silent at once, zero bus-errors	They have lost power; the bus is fine. A real CAN node at the wrong bitrate still generates errors, so total silence with a clean counter and the adapter still enumerated means nothing is transmitting. If it recurs between runs rather than during them, and on a joint drawing almost nothing, suspect the supply or its connection rather than current draw — watch the supply's own indicator at the moment it goes to tell a failing supply from failing wiring downstream of it.
Encoder tracks perfectly but the arm does not move	**Suspect the drivetrain, not the driver.** The encoder is on the motor shaft, upstream of the reduction, so slipping cycloidal gears produce a flawless trace — delivered counts matching commanded — for an output going nowhere. Slip also *unloads* the motor, so no stall, torque or position-error heuristic will fire. Confirm motion at the output before trusting any encoder result.
Endstop still silent after enabling `EndLimit`	`EndLimit` does not make an input *visible*. It governs only whether the driver *acts* on a limit. Reading the pin via `0x34` needs no `EndLimit` at all — on a 42D the missing piece is almost always the limit port remap.
Endstop never changes `0x34`, sensor LED does light	On a 42D, limit port remap is probably not enabled, so bit 0 is reporting the empty `IN_1` terminal rather than `En`. Send `9E 01`. There is no read-back, so it cannot be confirmed by query. Section 10.
Both endstop inputs read low at rest	Not "nothing connected" — an unwired input reads *high*. Most likely a reversed 3-pin sensor plug: `+V` sits in the middle, so reversing it swaps `Signal` and `GND` and straps the driver input to the module's ground while leaving the sensor powered and its LED lit. Turn the plug around.

Symptom	Likely cause and fix
A joint "stalls" partway through every move	Check the detector before the joint. A stick-slip joint jams, builds torque and breaks free: Joint B sticks for ∼2.9 s then surges and completes. A detector that aborts after 1.5 s reports that as a stall every time. Also exclude the acceleration and deceleration ramps — a move legitimately slows as it approaches target. **A stall means unable to move, not moving slowly.**
Repeated stalls while diagnosing	**Treat the stall count as a heat budget.** A stalled stepper holds full current while doing no work and makes no airflow, so it heats much faster than ordinary travel. Two motors have been overheated in this project, both during diagnosis rather than during use. Stop and let it cool.
Sensor shows no LED at all	**Try the other magnet face first.** These are unipolar hall parts: one face triggers them, the other does nothing whatsoever including the indicator. Three apparently-dead sensors on this arm have been resurrected by flipping the magnet. A dark LED also means the sensor is not detecting, so the driver, `Com` and remap are all irrelevant — investigating them is the mistake that cost two sessions on Joint B.
A 42D rests at `0x01`	Treat this as **remap off**, not as a triggered limit. On a 42D the byte is the same either way: remap off makes bit 1 a phantom reading 0, while remap on with `Dir` triggered reads identically. `0x9E` has no read-back, so toggle it and watch the byte move. Joint C's remap turned itself off between sessions and was misreported as a triggered limit for weeks.
Endstop fails, then works after a swap	**Swap the suspect part back before believing it.** Unplugging and replugging is itself a change, and the one most likely to clear an intermittent. If the fault does not return with the original part refitted, the part was never at fault and the problem is seating or contact — which will recur, most likely while the harness is flexing under motion.
Sensor LED lights but the `0x34` bit does not move	The sensor is detecting; the signal is not reaching the input pin. The fault is in the wire between them. Watching LED and bit together is what localises this.
Endstop bit flickers rapidly while parked	A magnet sitting at the edge of the sensor's range, crossing its threshold repeatedly. Release edges are narrow — 0.062° measured on Joint X. Move the sensor or magnet; do not fix it in software.
A move continues after the script exits	Expected. `ENABLE_MOTOR 00` does not cancel an in-flight `0xFD`; only `EMERGENCY_STOP (0xF7)` does. Send `0xF7` before the coil disable.

Symptom	Likely cause and fix
Motors hold torque the moment they are powered	The `En` option is set to `Hold` (always enabled). Set it back to active-low with `SET_EN_ACTIVE (0x85)` data `00`. Do not apply this to a joint using limit port remap, where `En` is a limit input.

12.1 Total silence with a powered driver: the RS485 variant

The MKS SERVO42D and SERVO57D ship in both CAN and RS485 variants. The RS485 boards have **no CAN transceiver at all** and will never appear on the bus at any bitrate or address. Joint X's driver turned out to be the RS485 variant, which is why it has never communicated. If a joint is silent across a full ID scan and a bitrate sweep, with power and wiring confirmed, **check the board's part number before spending any more time in software**.

13 The scripts in this package

All of these live in `~/arctos_ws/src/arctos_can_control/arctos_can_control`. Each takes `-can-id` and `-gear-ratio`; the motion ones also take an explicit safety band.

Script	What it does
`can_id_scan.py`	Read-only sweep of CAN IDs using `0x31`. Never enables coils. Run this before trusting any ID.
`joint_reliability_test.py`	Statistical encoder sampling at rest. Response rate, checksum failures, jitter, drift.
`joint_unstick_move_test.py`	Stepped `0xFD` travel in one direction with a back-off-and-retry cycle for a gritty mesh.
`joint_sweep_unstick_test.py`	Sweeps back and forth between two bounds for a fixed wall-clock duration, with the same unstick cycle and a total stall budget as a heat guard. Use when a rough spot needs crossing repeatedly.
`joint_speed_limit_test.py`	Ladder of commanded speeds across a fixed arc. Reports steady rpm, a whole-move average as a cross-check, and delivered position against commanded.
`joint_position_control_test.py`	Stepped position moves with retry. Superseded by the unstick variants for a suspect mesh.
`joint_endstop_test.py`	Read-only live monitor of the `0x34` byte. Sends nothing else, so it is safe on an assembled arm. Prints only when the byte changes.
`joint_endstop_dwell.py`	Timestamps every endstop edge and reports how long each trigger held, with a solid/chatter/marginal verdict. Use it when the monitor above shows a trigger but you need to know whether it is stable; that script has no timestamps, so a 50 ms tap and a two-second hold look identical there.
`joint_io_diff.py`	Sweeps every documented read-only register with the magnet away and then held on, reporting any byte that differs. For when an endstop does not appear on `0x34` at all.

Script	What it does
`joint_magnet_probe.py`	Checks whether an external magnet disturbs the encoder reading.
`joint_move.py`	`joint_move.py z cw 15`. One joint, a named direction, a distance. Direction is a name rather than a byte because the byte does not transfer between joints; unconfirmed joints are refused rather than guessed at. Endstop and stall aborts on by default, `0xF7` before the coil disable. **On an assembled arm:** `-leave-coils on` for a gravity-loaded joint, since disabling the coils lets it fall; `-stall-window 5` for a sticky joint; `-assume-cw` to make a first, deliberately-unverified move on a joint whose direction is unknown.
`joint_calibrate.py`	`joint_calibrate.py z`. Sweeps to both limits at one speed and reports the separation. Imports the joint table from `joint_move.py` so the direction mappings live in one place. Run it twice — a single figure is not a result.
`joint_roundtrip.py`	`joint_roundtrip.py 45`, or `-joints x,z`. Moves each joint out and back and reports how far from its start it finished. Skips joints that are not on the bus or have no confirmed direction mapping, so it works on a partly assembled arm. Flags a leg that stopped early, whose return error describes an interrupted move rather than a drivetrain.

14 ROS 2 package layout

The workspace is a standard ROS 2 layout. The CAN work lives in `src/arctos_can_control`; `src/ros2_arctos` carries the description, MoveIt configuration and hardware interface.

```
cd ~/arctos_ws
colcon build --packages-select arctos_can_control
source install/setup.bash
```

The Python test scripts above do not need the workspace built or sourced. They talk to SocketCAN directly and can be run from the source directory, which is why every procedure in the SOPs uses them rather than ROS 2 nodes.

15 Corrections, and what this set replaces

These four documents replace five older ones. The following items were **wrong** in those files and were corrected here, so do not re-derive them from any surviving copy.

- **Joint B and C CAN IDs.** Joint B is `0x05` and Joint C is `0x06`, as the older files and the controller config state. An interim revision of this document asserted the reverse after a scan found Joint B answering on `0x06`; that driver's panel ID was wrong, and the map was right. Scan before driving, and correct the panel.

- **Encoder opcode.** An old guide standardized on `0x30` and described `0x31` as unverified. That is backwards. `0x31` is what the real C++ driver uses and what every script here uses.
- **Bitrate verification.** An old guide instructed the reader to run `ip link set can0 up type can bitrate 500000` and then verify by looking for `bitrate 500000`. Neither works on slcan.
- **Bus error counters.** Old troubleshooting advice leaned on bus-error counts that the slcan driver never populates.
- **Motion command.** An old safe-first-motion procedure was built on `0xF5`, whose absolute-versus-relative behaviour it correctly flagged as unresolved. That question is moot: use `0xFD`.
- **Missing checksums.** The old cheat sheet listed `cansend can0 005#F300` and `cansend can0 005#F7` with no checksum byte at all. Both would be rejected. The correct frames are `005#F300F8` and `005#F7FC`.
- **Speed ceiling.** The no-load figure of 225 rpm was presented as a general operating limit. It is a bare-motor number; Joint B saturates at about 165.